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Canadian charity Up With Women/Exponenti'elles named one of Fast Company's 100 Best Workplaces for Innovators

TORONTO, ON — Up With Women/Exponenti'elles (UWW/EXP), a Canadian charity pioneering a new approach to addressing poverty among women and gender-diverse people, has been named one of *Fast Company*'s 100 Best Workplaces for Innovators for 2026, joining a global roster of organizations recognized for fostering a culture of innovation at all levels. At UWW/EXP, that culture empowers employees to turn bold ideas into meaningful impact.

"This recognition belongs to the extraordinary community behind this work: our clients, volunteer coaches, partners, donors, and supporters," said Lia Grimanis, Founder and CEO of Up With Women/Exponenti'elles. "This honour elevates Canadian innovation on the global stage and advances the conversation around economic barriers faced by women and gender-diverse people. When we change how we approach a problem—and who gets to be part of creating the solution—we open the door to new possibilities. That's where true innovation happens."

The awards have previously recognized global innovators such as Google, Siemens and L'Oréal, underscoring the significance of UWW/EXP's recognition as a growing Canadian charity bringing innovation to the complex challenge of gendered poverty. UWW/EXP was also named one of *Fast Company*'s Small but Mighty Companies, honouring organizations with fewer than 100 employees that have cultivated workplaces where innovation can thrive. Together, the dual recognition shines an international spotlight on a Canadian non-profit helping women and gender-diverse people overcome barriers to economic opportunity through an innovative, community-based model.

Founded in 2009, UWW/EXP was born from Lia Grimanis' lived experience of violence and homelessness and her determination to help women and gender-diverse people facing similar barriers find pathways to meaningful employment and financial stability. Today, UWW/EXP has mobilized a national community of nearly 500 volunteer professional coaches to support clients.

The organization's strengths-based coaching model is grounded in a simple premise: clients are the experts in their own lives. They define their own goals, supported by coaches who help them build confidence and take steps to achieve them.

The model is delivering measurable results. An analysis of UWW/EXP's 2025 clients, comparing outcomes from intake to graduation, found that:

- annual client income increased by an average of 157 per cent;
- reliance on social assistance decreased by 38 per cent, while full-time employment increased by 180 per cent; and

- more than 90 per cent of clients reported greater confidence and progress toward their goals.

Together, these outcomes affirm the value of community-driven innovation that puts people at the centre of addressing real-world challenges.

That commitment to lived experience is reflected in UWW/EXP's leadership. Its staff and Board include former clients and individuals with firsthand experience of the barriers the organization works to address, ensuring that lived expertise informs organizational strategy, program design and decision-making. At UWW/EXP innovation is a shared responsibility. People at all levels are empowered to identify challenges, improve processes and design solutions informed by the lived experiences and realities of the clients they serve.

The 2026 Best Workplaces for Innovators will be recognized at the *Fast Company* Innovation Festival on September 16 in New York City.

"Gendered poverty is one of Canada's most persistent challenges, but it is also an opportunity for innovation," said Grimanis. "Addressing it calls for solutions that are community-led and grounded in the perspectives of those closest to the issues. We're honoured that *Fast Company* has recognized a model built on that belief."

ABOUT UP WITH WOMEN/EXPONENTI'ELLES

Up With Women/Exponenti'elles (UWW/EXP) is a Canadian charity dedicated to helping women and gender-diverse people build sustainable pathways out of poverty. Through year-long professional coaching and wraparound support, UWW/EXP empowers clients to achieve their goals and create secure, thriving futures. Supported by a national network of volunteer professional coaches, UWW/EXP advances economic equity through innovative, community-driven solutions to gendered poverty.

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